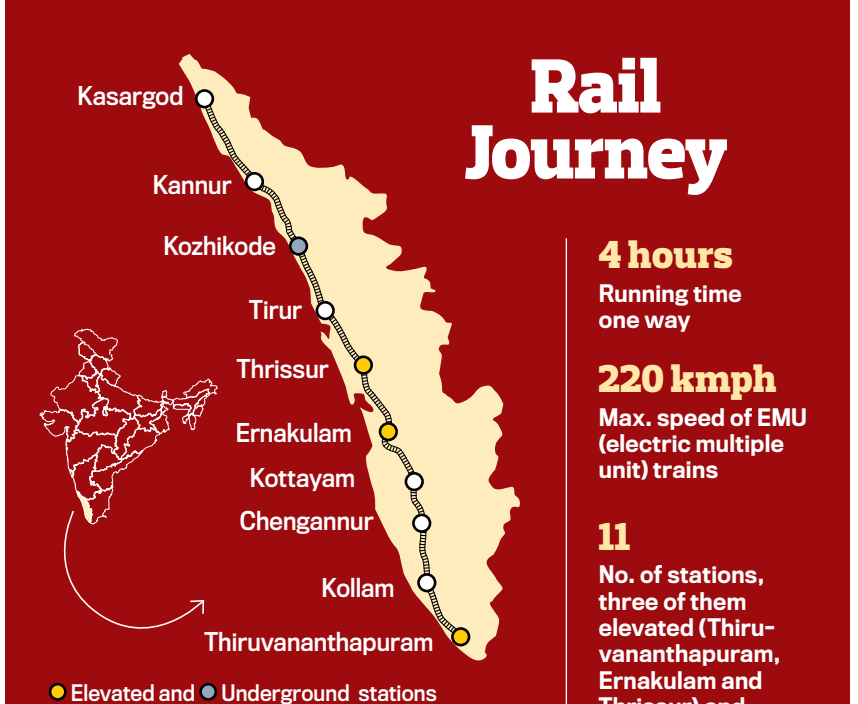
But Pinarayi is powering ahead, for he believes a first-world transportation scheme like K-Rail will be his legacy in the state. Also, the way the previous big protests withered over time has given him the confidence that the people are with him. It helps that the Left Front government has a brute majority in the assembly and the CPI(M) cadre have some control over the street narratives.

HEADING TOWARD DEBT?

Project estimates started at a little less than Rs 64,000 crore in 2020, but with the delays, some experts predict cost overruns to be more than 60 per cent. The NITI Aayog, for instance, puts it at twice the official figure: Rs 1.25 lakh crore. But K-Rail does get the thumbs up from some others. An estimate audit done by RITES (Rail India Technical and Economic Services) says the project could be much cheaper—Rs 120 crore/km—than, say, the Delhi-Meerut rail corridor (estimate: Rs 360 crore/ km).

For now, the plan is that the Kerala government will spend Rs 18,150 crore of its own money, with the Centre putting in Rs 6,313 crore. The state will raise Rs 4,251 crore through shares and bonds from the public and Rs 33,670 crore through external borrowings. The state government has approached ADB (Asian Development Bank) and the Japan International Cooperation Agency (JICA) for funds. The latter has agreed to lend Rs 20,000 crore at an interest rate of 0.25 per cent. ADB has also offered loans, at 1-1.5 per cent.

But there are critics here, too, who believe the largesse comes at a price. Environmental scientist and KSSP patron Dr R.V.G. Menon says, "The project is economically unviable and based on outdated technology. It may end up like the Kochi Metro Rail, which is still making huge losses. Japan is offering loans at low rates because it wants to sell us its outdated technology. They have shelved the



PLUSES

- SilverLine trains will connect all the major business corridors in the state. Big boost for the economy expected. 50,000 new jobs during construction period; 10,000 when it's onstream
- Less land to be acquired per km (2.4 ha.) for SilverLine than, say, for road widening or an expressway (6.1 ha.). This means fewer families affected in a high density population state
- SilverLine will reportedly use 100% renewable energy; annual average emissions reduction of 2,87,994 tonnes CO_2/year, estimates EIA report
- 82,000 riders daily expected by 2028. Elevated corridors and stations could become new business centres. Also, 8 out of 11 stations are on city outskirts, could transform into residential hubs, reducing pressure on downtown areas in cities

MINUSES

- In 2020, project costs started with Rs 63,491 crore but already delayed by two years, cost overruns could now be as high as 60%. Many experts fear Kerala could be staring at a debt trap with K-Rail
- Some 15,000 families will lose their homes/ property to K-Rail, a big reason why there is stiff opposition to the project
- Hydrological EIA says the threat of floods in a state that gets rain now almost nine months a year has to be taken into account. The environmental impact due to 'construction of bridges, viaducts, cutting, cut & cover and tunnels also need to be assessed'
- Ridership concerns, with some experts pointing to Kochi Metro, which is struggling to make money